security advisors, distinguished nuclear scientists, the chiefs of staff, etc. I did the speech from the Oval Office at 8 and then joined the party for coffee. I guess it was okay, they all praised it to the sky and seemed to think it would be a source of debate for some time to come. I did the bulk of the speech on why our arms buildup was necessary and then finished with a call to the science community to join me in research starting now to develop defensive weapons that would render nuclear missiles obsolete. I made no optimistic forecasts—said it might take 20 years or more but we had to do it. I felt good.

March 24

. . . the reports are in on last night's speech. The biggest return—phone calls, wires, etc., on any speech so far and running heavily in my favor. . . .

March 25

Meeting with speech writers—gave them an idea for Saturday radio; it worked out pretty good. A poll taken before the speech shows I've gained on job approval with regard to the economy, but the drum beat of anti-defense propaganda has reduced my rating on foreign affairs. I'll be interested to see how that holds for a poll after the speech. Did a press availability in the press room. It went well, so the press on TV almost ignored it entirely. . . .

April 6

Learned George Shultz is upset. Thinks N.S.C. is undercutting him on plans he and I discussed for "quiet diplomacy" approach to the Soviets [which led to the release of the Pentecostalist families in Moscow, but] we had a meeting later in day with George and cleared things up I think. Some of the N.S.C. staff are too hard